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Master Of Penguins

Your passion for Linux can broaden your future prospects...

Samir Makwana

Linus Torvalds, the father of Linux, adopted the penguin, nicknamed Tux (because penguins look like they're wearing tuxedos), as the Linux mascot. Tux was later adopted by the Linux community as the mascot of the Linux kernel, and that's what the majority of people associate Linux with.

The Linux kernel, which started off life as a hobby of Torvalds', had 10,000 lines of code, and was released under the public licence. The open source community has been actively involved in the development and support of Linux. Today, many Linux distributions for specific use are available for free or commercially, with software packs bundled to meet users' requirements.

Commercially-available Linux OSes include Red Hat Linux, Novell's SUSE, TurboLinux's Fuji Linux, BOSS Linux, and many others. A large number of community-driven Linux flavours is also available worldwide.

Why Linux?

Why not? Linux is a robust, flexible, and transparent open source operating system. The Open Source Software community provides a variety of software packages to be used with Linux OSes for specific purposes. Many Individual Software Vendors (ISVs) offer software packages with Windows integration and after-sales support.

Support for community-driven software is available from members of the community. Linux is freely modifiable; it can be tweaked for optimum performance. It also offers flexibility and interoperability with several proprietary OSes.



Across the globe, the use of Linux within the business segments—as well as governments—is spreading at an unprecedented rate. Search giant Google has several terabytes of data in its index: it uses 3,500 Linux computers to respond to search queries and index pages from the Web. Besides that, corporate giants including computer OEMs (Original Equipment Manufacturers), banks, online shopping portals, and many other industries use mission-critical applications on Linux-based servers.

Scene India

The trend is currently a gradual shift towards Linux. It's happening in too many cases for us to ignore it. The best example would be that of the Life Insurance Corporation of India: they shifted their IT requirements onto Linux servers in 2005. After saving Rs 20 lakh by using free software, LIC expects to soon have more than 1,00,000 computers running on Linux.

Indian enterprises were indeed initially hesitant to adopt Linux. It was used in non-mission-critical operations like Web hosting. But today, the Indian corporate sector is playing a major role in showing the way to migrate to Linux. Linux has gained a strong foothold in the server space. According to IDC reports, Linux servers represented 12.7 per cent of the overall server market, which is \$1.6 billion (Rs 6,400 crore) for the Q1 2007. Nandkumar Pradhan, president and managing director, Red Hat India, states, "The technical capabilities of Linux are growing with technologies like virtualisation, real-time computing, security, etc. being built into the operating system. The awareness of the capabilities of Linux and open source is growing, and this will lead to more rapid adoption over the next few years in India."